Proto-Indus script

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CQRL Bits

In this short description we follow the stages of development of the Indus script during the development of towns (ūr).

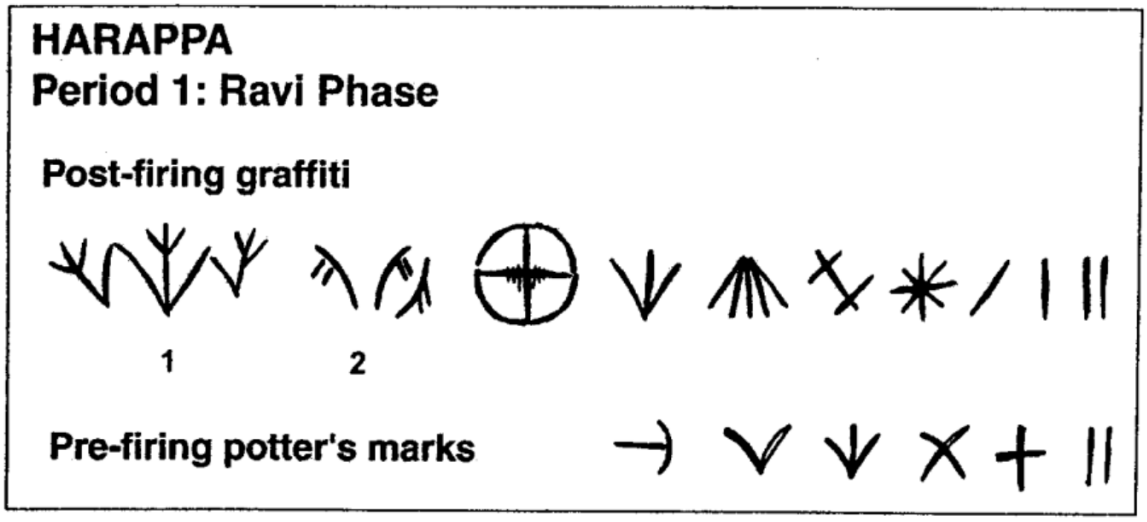

Figure 3. Harappa, Ravi Phase Script

We can note the possible ideation for logo-syllables like vēl, mutal, iru, mu, viri, kuti, cēri.

The sun is star-shaped ✳.
The above Potter's marks were observed in the first phase, the Ravi Phase (3200-2800 BCE).
The tools they used were bone tools:

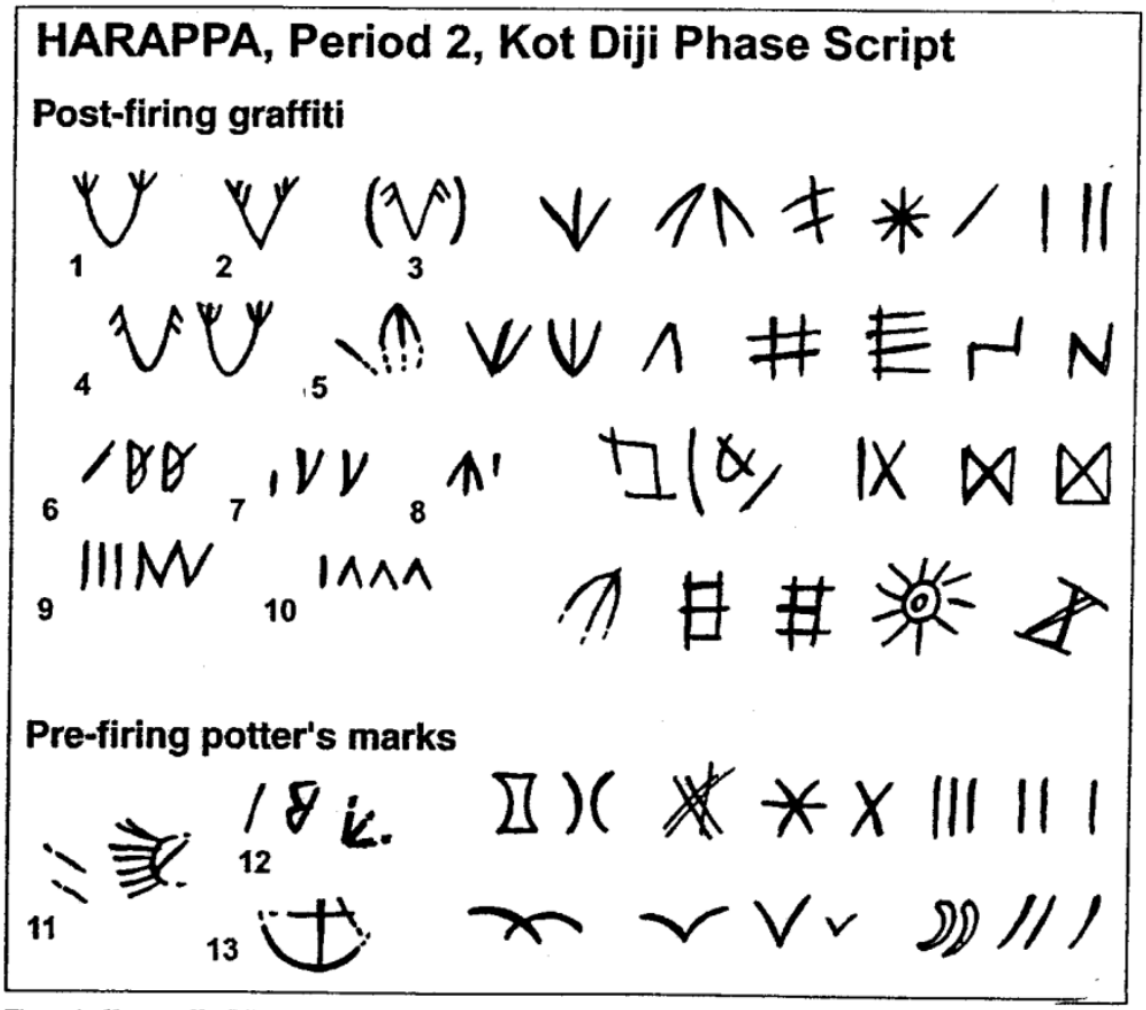

Figure 4. Harappa, Kot Diji Phase Script

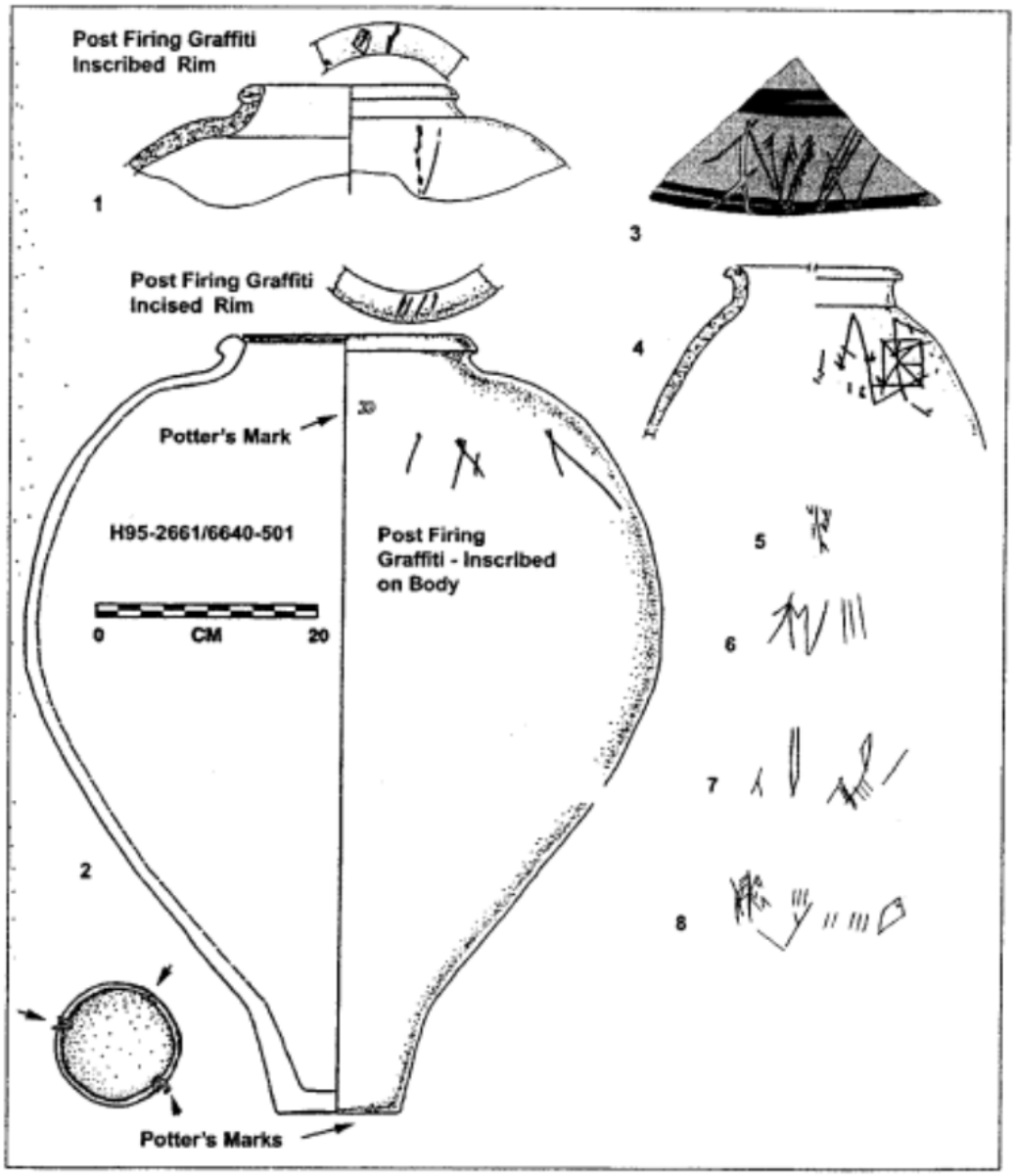

Figure 7. Harappa Period Inscribed Pottery

1. Black Slipped Jar, post-firing graffiti on rim and body (H95 / 5684-02)
2. Black Slipped Jar, post-firing graffiti on rim and body, pre-firing potter's marks on base and body (H95-2662 / 6640-501)
3. Large Red Slipped Black Band Jar, post-firing graffiti on body (H94 / 4290-14)
4. Plain globular jar, post-firing graffiti on body (H95 / 5630-15)
5. Black Slipped Jar, post-firing graffiti on body (H93 / 4305-500)
6. Black Slipped Jar, post-firing graffiti on body (H93 / 4159-500)
7. Black Slipped Jar, post-firing graffiti on body (H93 / 4043-503)
8. Black Slipped Jar, post-firing graffiti on body (H93 / 4304-500)

We can note the beginning stages of creation of logo-syllables like: vēl-ūr, valai-ūr, vilampu, taṭṭi, pura, iru-vaṟi, etc.

In this Period-2, the sun is portrayed now not as a star ✳ as in Period-1, but as ☼, which eventually became a hollow ellipse ○ in the mature stage of Indus script.

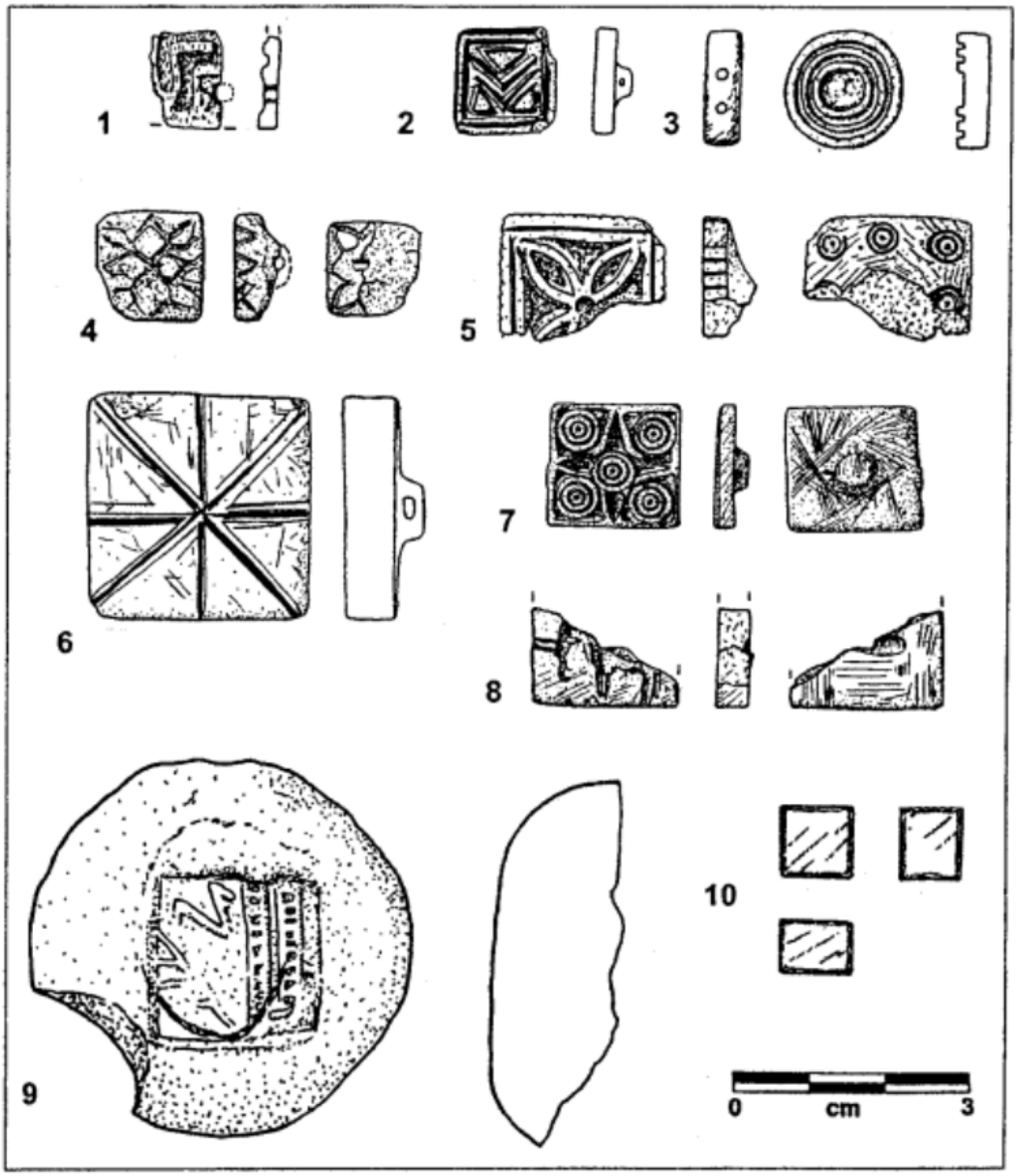

Figure 5. Harappa, Ravi and Kot Diji Phase Seals

1. Button Seal, bone, Ravi Phase Period 1 (H98-3503/8514-07)
2. Button Seal, glazed steatite, Kot Diji Phase, Period 2 (H96-2740/7469-01)
3. Button Seal, glazed steatite, Kot Diji Phase, Period 2 (H96/7458-01)
4. Button Seal, glazed steatite, Kot Diji Phase, Period 2 (H98-3453/8301-01)
5. Button Seal, glazed steatite, Kot Diji Phase, Period 2 (H98-3493/8314-01)
6. Button Seal, unfired steatite, Kot Diji Phase, Period 2 (H96-2743/7402-90)
7. Button Seal, glazed steatite, Kot Diji Phase, Period 2 (H2000-4495/9597-010
8. Elephant Seal, glazed steatite, Kot Diji Phase, Period 2 (H2000-4474/8994-01)
9. Terracotta sealing, Kot Diji Phase, Period 2 (H98-3485/8437-01)
10. Limestone cubical weight, Kot Diji Phase, Period 2 (H98-3430/8499-16)

Early Food Producing Era	*circa + 7000 to 5000 B.C.*
Regionalization Era	*circa 5000 to 2600 B.C.*
Harappa Period 1A/B (Hakra/Ravi)	>3700-2800 B.C.
Harappa Period 2 (Kot Dijian)	2800-2600 B.C.
Integration Era	***2600 to 1900 B.C.***
Harappa Period 3A	2600-2450 B.C.
Harappa Period 3B	2450-2200 B.C.
Harappa Period 3C	2200-1900 B.C.
Localization Era	*1900 to 1300 B.C.*
Harappa Period 4 (Late Harappan)	1900-1800 B.C.
Harappa Period 5 (Late Harappan/Cemetery H)	1800-<1700 B.C.

Table 2. General Chronology: Indus Tradition and Harappa Chronology

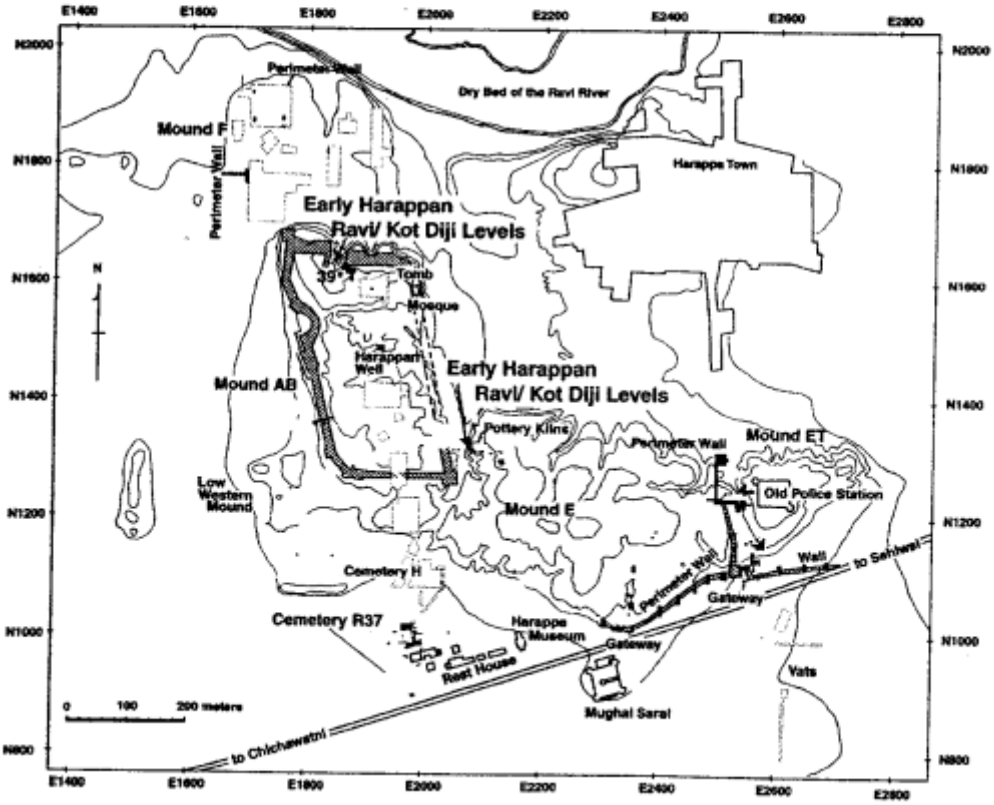

Figure 2. Map of Harappa

The next stage is a great leap forward to a new punctuated equilibrium [3], with the blossoming of a new proto-Dravidian language and it's logo-syllabic vocabulary of more than 400 signs.

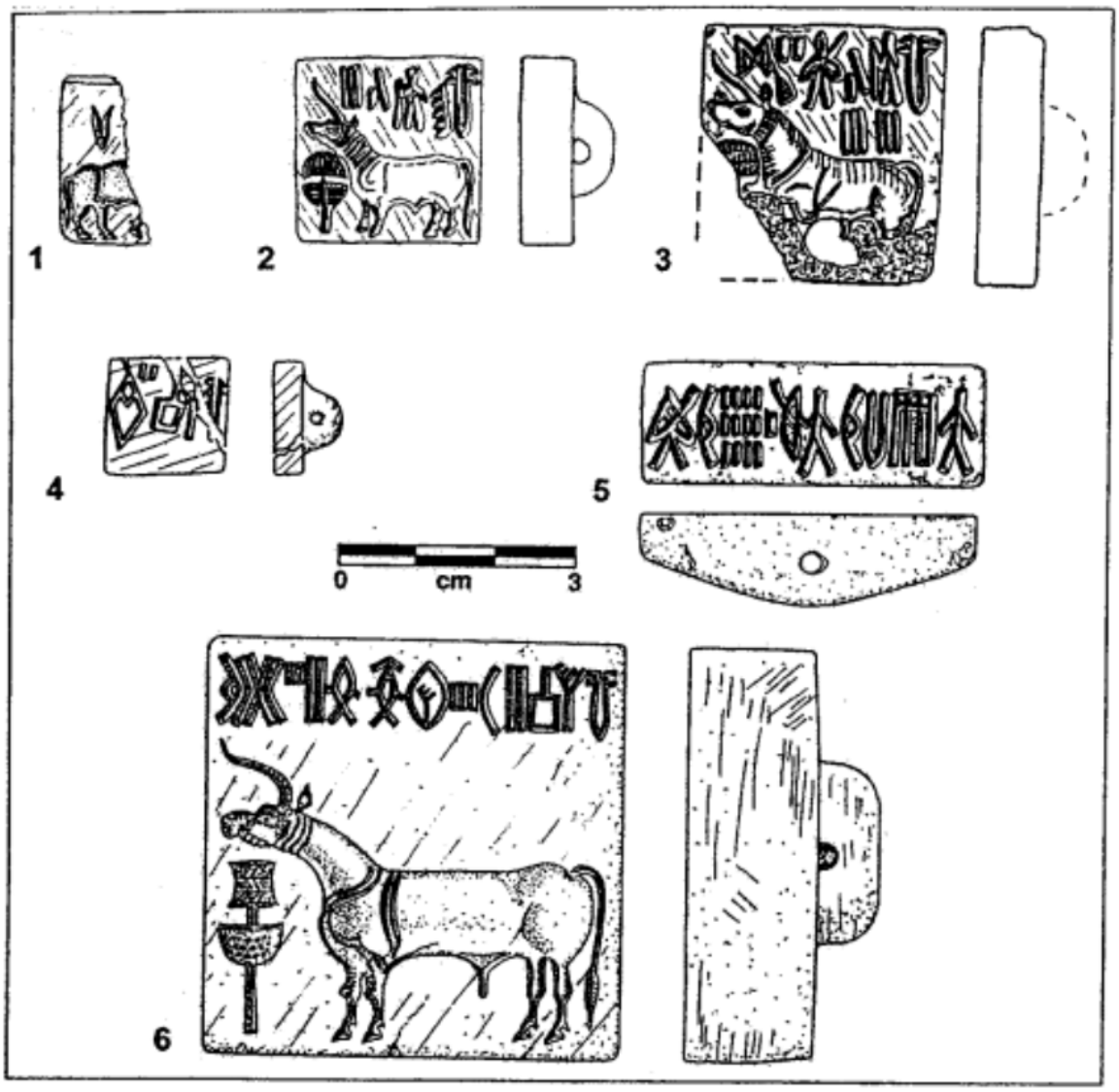

Figure 6. Harappa Phase Intaglio Seals

1. Steatite seal, Period 3A, (H90-1600/3166-01)
2. Steatite seal, Period 3B, (H95-2491/4690-01)
3. Steatite seal, Period 3B, (H95-2410 / 5145-55)
4. Steatite seal, Period 3B/3C, (H93-2170 / 4114-09)
5. Steatite seal, Period 3C, (H98-3491/8322-21)
6. Steatite seal, Period 3C, (H99-4064/8796-01)

References

[1] Kenoyer, J.M. (2006) The Origin, Context and Function of Indus Script: Recent Insights from Harappa, *Proceedings of the Research Institute for Humanity and Nature* (RIHM), Kyoto.
[2] Venkatesan, S.K. (2025) Decipherment of Indus Valley Script, https://github.com/Sukii/decipher-ivc
[3] Dixon R.M.W., *The Rise and Fall of Languages*, Cambridge University Press, 2012